

César





SALMON

Smoked Norwegian Salmon Rillettes in a crispy Feuille de Brick

SHIMA AJI

Koshihikari Rice on a Crispy Nori with Ginger and Shiso

MONAKA

A Japanese Monaka Holding Atlantic Royal Red Prawn, Trout Roe, and Arare
Served with Avocado Wasabi Mousse, Hojiso, Myoga, and added Hokkaido Bafun Uni by Marutaku Suisan

FISH & CHIP

Kisu Weaved in a Potato Crisp

UNI TOAST

Hokkaido Bafun Uni by Marutaku Suisan
Black Truffle and Toasted Brioche

TUNA

Tuna Akami from Kindai University, Crispy kombu, Mustard mousse, Pickled fennel, and Yuzu Dressing

CHAWANMUSHI

Egg Flan with a Mixture of Mushrooms and Truffle Miso Dashi

SCALLOP

Seared Stonington Hand-Dived Scallop from Maine
Served with Napa Cabbage, Mushroom Raviolo, Morel, Turnip, a Vin Jaune Sauce and Onion Espuma

CRISPY SOURDOUGH

SQUAB

Squab from Wolfe Ranch, Radicchio di Treviso Tardivo, Grilled Scallion, Maitake Mushroom
Sausage, Spinach Purée, Squab jus, Onion Cream, and Orange Reduction

PALATE CLEANSER

Harry's Berry Strawberry Compote, Yogurt Ice Cream
Coconut and Lychee Granita, Mint, and Riesling Gelée

FROZEN SOUFFLÉ

Tahitian Vanilla Ice Cream, Vanilla Cream, Vanilla Powder, Armagnac Sauce

PETIT FOURS

Black Berry with Lime Jelly
Soy Caramel
Chocolate Lava Cake



César Ramirez's cuisine is not new to me, but César is. Curious about his new establishment, I booked César once I began planning my return to Manhattan. Anchored by a spacious, J-shaped counter, the new space unfolds on a larger scale comparing to the original Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare. I had reserved a table at first, then changed to the counter, suspecting the dining room lighting might be dim. What's sarcastic is that as we arrive at the door, we are informed that there is a problem with the lighting above the counter, thus all counter guests will be seated at tables this evening. The disappointment gradually dissolves as we get comfortably languid on the couch. On the table, a modern crystal lamp cast a soft, amber glow across the white cloth, the light settling gently into the space. What I had tried to avoid becomes, unexpectedly, the more fitting place to be.

A tray arrives at the table swiftly, exhibiting a selection of luxury ingredients — Hokkaido uni, caviar, black truffle, and foie gras — available as supplements to the tasting menu. The gesture, unlike a praising ceremony to what the kitchen has prepared, is a pure commercial act of selling, a decaying lament that carries dissonance. It brings to mind a different time in fine dining, one that now feels increasingly distant. I remember myself once praising the inclusion of an A5 cut of Miyazaki wagyu at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, something that, by my return visit in 2022, had already been moved to the supplements. Now, even the caviar course has disappeared from the menu, reappearing instead as an eighty-dollar addition. That being said, this interlude quickly recedes as the first bites begin to arrive.



Just as I remembered from his previous kitchen, the dinner unfolds on a series of small bites, opening with a cigarette-shaped *feuille de brick* filled with smoked Norwegian salmon rillettes. The gesture is simple, but fine dining is precisely defined less by complexity than by finesse. The outer layer carries an almost ethereal lightness. It shatters delicately on contact, giving way to a filling that exudes a gentle, lingering smokiness — rich, but never heavy. The rilette spreads slowly across the palate, its texture revealing itself in contrast that departs from the seamless monotony of a *pâté* and instead, emerges as something more grounded, laced with fine strands of salmon that give it structure and a subdued depth. Then, on a vintage-style Christofle Albi silver asparagus server rests something unmistakably familiar: two pieces of gunkanmaki crowned with shima aji, one of my favorite nigiri neta. The gunkan has shrunk in size, but the crispness of the nori remains just as I remember. Ramirez's seasoning here has become more discreet, with a refreshing ginger and shiso duo replacing the richer, more umami-driven profile I encountered before.





The only supplement we opt for is the uni, which will be added to the monaka dish that, based on my own judgement, can be further sublimated by the presence of this creamy sweet ocean creature. Monaka later becomes one of Ramirez's signature dishes after my latest visit to the Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, though I have no fortune to taste it. The monaka as a savory bite, nonetheless, is something not new to me as a fond memory of uni monaka by Ichimura still lingers in my mind, perhaps another reason why I add uni to this dish. In this case the monaka, logically speaking, acts just like a tartlet in modern haute cuisine, but with a much lighter, airy texture. In this composition, the Atlantic royal red prawn takes the spotlight, surrounded by a microsphere duo of trout roe and arare for distinct textures. At the base is a verdant mousse of avocado and wasabi, then the quintessential staples of Japanese seasonings, hojiso and myoga, crowned the bite, together with the added Hokkaido bafun uni by Marutaku Suisan. Ramirez has kindly cut the monaka in half, not only favoring us to enjoy this more gracefully but also inviting us to take a better look at the cross section. The whole medley exudes an authentic Japanese temperament albeit the presence of avocado, which interestingly evokes guacamole in Mexican cuisine if one considers Ramirez's roots. On the palate, the monaka encourages pure enjoyment rather than scrutiny and analysis. It is a polyphony of textures and a sheer fiesta of the oceanic mellow umami.



A new composition arrives soon after we finish the last bite, marking the first bite that holds some warmth. Set on a Hering Berlin Evolution oval amuse-bouche plate is a single potato chip, delicately topped with a piece of Kisu that, upon closer inspection, is partially woven into the chip.

The server introduces it as Ramirez's interpretation of fish and chips, an idea that holds, at least on the surface. In practice, however, the influence of Japanese tempura is far more pronounced than the English reference. Kisu, a Japanese whiting, is prized for its clean, delicate, slightly sweet flavor. While a whiting could be an alternative choice for fish and chips, Kisu, specifically, is known as a staple of traditional tempura. Here, the thin potato chip mimics the role of batter, while the Kisu, probably steamed, is expressed with a purity that is clean and noble, following tempura aesthetics.

It is a minimalistic composition, built on just two elements, yet again the precision here sublimates the dish. The only misstep comes from the chip, whose slight excess oil detracts from the lightness one expects of a refined tempura-inspired bite.



Following this fish and chip comes the *pièce de résistance* of Ramirez, a generous serving of uni on top of a brioche pillow. Once shaped round, the brioche has been changed to a rectangular shape and has also shrunk in size. The possible reward for this diminution is that the piece can be enjoyed in one bite. This signature uni toast showcases another example of minimal execution, there is just a touch of black truffle between the uni and the toast. This isn't Ramirez's own creation, in fact, this combination roots in continental dining and has become popular in this modern form through chefs like Jean-Georges and Joshua Skenes from Saison. However, Ramirez proves again, through his precise execution, that restraint and finesse are what really matter.

The brioche, instead of being richly buttered, is prepared with just the right amount to achieve a balance of projected richness and aroma, while acting like a canvas for the uni to fully shine through. This uni doesn't hail from the esteemed producers you'd expect at a high-end omakase spot; instead, it comes from Marutaku Suisan, a rather niche producer. In a single mouthful, the palate is engulfed by a tsunami of flavor that perfectly balances oceanic freshness with a rich, bright sweetness.



Ensuing a series of seafood bites, the tuna finally makes its appearance. Sourced intriguingly from Kindai University, the sashimi is topped with crisp kombu and gently bathed in a refreshing yuzu dressing. Beneath the sashimi, a mustard mousse unfolds alongside pickled fennel, lending both depth and contrast to the composition.

The crispy kombu proves a thoughtful addition to the composition, and a rather rare touch, as I have not seen it featured in this course in images of the dish from both before and after this dinner. Kombu itself is not new to me, nor to Ramirez, as it also appears in the wagyu tartlet during my latest visit to the Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, , suggesting a quiet through-line in his vocabulary. This dish seems to present a variation of the infamous parfait. I nonetheless prefer the latter for its more harmonious texture and the ingenious use of gelée. Yet there is a certain intellectual pleasure in encountering this alternative expression as its unfamiliar form offers, through contrast, a clearer and more nuanced understanding of both interpretations.



While I dare not to consider myself a tuna expert, ample experience allows me a certain level of knowledge on different fishing methods, notable vendors, and the many lesser-known cuts beyond the canonical trio. Thus, it is almost astonishing to learn that the tuna in this dish comes from Kindai University — a detail that immediately draws my attention. This tuna, as I come to understand, represents the world's first successful full-cycle aquaculture of Pacific bluefin, raised entirely from egg to maturity over the course of three years. Produced within a university fisheries laboratory, Kindai is often presented as a more sustainable and potentially more health-conscious alternative. Supply, however, remains exceedingly limited: each week, a single shipment typically comprising just three fish is flown from Japan to the United States, with one allocated to New York and the remaining two to the Bay Area. As such, encountering Kindai tuna is less a matter of choice than of circumstance, its presence on a menu quietly signaling both privilege and access. On the palate, the flesh reveals a striking purity — clean, precise, and almost crystalline in its expression — allowing the character of akami to emerge in what feels like its most essential form.



What follows the tuna is another old acquaintance, a mushroom cappuccino presented in a Hering Berlin Cielo beaker. Here, a medley of mushrooms is drenched in a truffle miso dashi, resting on top of a soft egg flan base. The server introduces the dish with a deliberate, almost performative emphasis on the flan, as if seeking to ennoble it, though it is in essence an alternative expression of either chawanmushi or egg custard. The focus, however, remains firmly on the mushrooms. Modest in portion, the flan functions more as a supporting role, when taken with the spoon, it contributes primarily as a textural element within the soup rather than asserting itself as a central presence. Once accompanied by foie gras and escargot, the dish now appears more restrained in composition. In this instance, I find myself preferring the richer iteration, as the pared-down selection of ingredients does not fully align with the unctuous depth of the broth, resulting in a slight sense of imbalance.

As the soup signals the conclusion of the small bites, a scallop dish arrives, ushering in the main courses. A round, gorgeously seared hand-dived scallop from Stonington nestles in a frothy bath of onion espuma and vin jaune sauce, beneath which lies a medley of napa cabbage, morel mushroom, turnip, and a mushroom raviolo. Rather than the so-called perfect execution of a butter-basted scallop marked by a deep brown Maillard crust, the scallop here is treated with gentle elegance, allowing it to reveal a more refined texture — one that feels almost intimate on the palate. On the palate, an almost candy-like sweetness emerges from the flesh, accompanied by a distinct umami complexity. The sauces are classical and soothing, both onion and vin jaune lend depth of flavor to the scallop, carried through a texture that remains miraculously light and airy.

Beneath this cloud lies something of a hidden trove, where a variety of ingredients is presented without any sense of excess. Instead, the cabbage and turnip subtly evoke an East Asian sensibility. In their simplest poached form, they lend gentle green aromas to the dish. The mushroom raviolo, together with the morel, offers an intriguing counterpoint. Its dough is fully cooked, which is perhaps not ideal if judged on its own terms, but within the composition, it contributes to a more cohesive, almost homogeneous texture, reinforcing the dish's overall harmony.

Presented alongside the scallop dish is a sourdough. Cradled in a silver basket, the round-shaped loaf carries a graceful appearance, almost resembling a brioche. Its crust is highly crisp, and the interior remains moist and richly aromatic, offering considerable pleasure on the palate. The pairing, nonetheless, feels somewhat disjointed, as the rustic and untamed character of the bread tends to overwhelm the delicacy of the scallop dish.





Just as the scallop dish prepares me to embrace the main courses, the climax arrives almost immediately, presenting an abrupt finale. It takes the form of a squab dish. At its center, a precisely rare breast, accompanied by grilled maitake mushroom, a sausage filled with the trimmings of the squab and spinach, as well as grilled scallion and a single petal of tardivo — a prized winter chicory from Italy's Veneto region. Alongside is a quartet of sauces: a squab jus, an orange reduction, a spinach purée, and an onion cream. Though the composition differs entirely from what I encounter at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, the sauces once again reveal Ramirez's underlying logic, which I have encountered before in his wagyu dish. Each element articulates a distinct axis of flavor, the vegetal clarity of the spinach, the gentle sweetness of the orange reduction that serves the bird perfectly, then the jus as a quintessential anchor, supplemented by the onion cream, which lends a further touch of rounded, almost enveloping depth. As with the scallop, the squab is accompanied by a medley of seemingly modest garnishes that, together, achieve a quiet precision. The maitake brings an earthy, almost wooded resonance, its grilled edges echoing the depth of the jus. The sausage, enriched by the bird's own trimmings, reinforces the identity of the squab while introducing a denser, more savory register. The scallion offers a lifted, charcoal-scented sharpness, cutting through the richness with vibrancy, while the tardivo contributes a restrained bitterness — cool, crisp, and faintly floral — that resets the palate. Individually, each component speaks in a distinct language; together, they form a fine counterpoint, balancing earthiness, unctuousness, brightness, and bitterness in a way that feels at once meticulous and harmonious.



The palate cleanser again brings back familiarity. In a simple white bowl rests a pure white granita shavings, and that's all we can see. As we take the spoon and carefully unveil the coconut and lychee cloud, the underneath reveals an orchard before us — pieces of strawberry compote, a yogurt ice cream, and some riesling gelée. This composition soon casts a soft echo of past experiences of the equivalent dish at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, a remix of components held in the chef's repertoire. It reflects a similar approach of a January 2023 version of fresh tangerine and yogurt sorbet with rosé gel, intertwined with a May 2022 version, where cantaloupe met the Riesling gel. In his hands, these familiar elements are a deck of cards constantly reshuffled, yielding endless variations.

Taking a spoonful, the familiar combination soon gives way to something unfamiliar, something that troubles my mind. The entire composition is built around the strawberry base, which is poached and thus becomes more akin to a sundae topping, rather than expressing the orchard-like freshness that would cleanse the palate. Moreover, the texture of the yogurt ice cream has significantly thickened, further diminishing the dish's sense of refreshment. While the riesling gelée is intended as an important element, its presence here feels rather recessive. A composition such as this reads more as a main dessert than as a palate cleanser.



The frozen soufflé dessert evokes a landscape I have known by heart since my first encounter with Ramirez's cuisine. Along with the uni toast, it stands as his most celebrated *pièce de résistance*. After traveling through flavors of sobacha, strawberry, and tiramisu, I am finally brought home to a vanilla version — a return to the genesis of it all, and a true classic. This frozen soufflé is a hymn to Tahitian vanilla, layering it in elegant variations of texture: from the density and suaveness of the underlying ice cream to the airy lift of a chiffon base and the velvety embrace of a cream sauce. Most sacredly, a powder of vanilla caviar coats the surface like a constellation of dark, aromatic dust. Beneath it all, a touch of Armagnac sauce saturates the dessert, lending a hidden, amber depth to the finish.

Tahitian vanilla offers a sweet, delicate flavor often compared to wine, flowers, and ripe fruit. With higher levels of heliotropin and anisaldehyde, it carries a distinct floral and anise-like scent. Unlike the rich, creamy Madagascar vanilla, the Tahitian variety is lighter and more nuanced, making it ideal for creams and pastries. In this composition, the Tahitian vanilla finds its most profound expression. However, it is precisely this precious, delicate aroma that makes the interference — an intrusive mechanical odor — exceptionally abominable. While this vanilla version carries a certain grace, a creamier, more indulgent texture would elevate it further. While vanilla and tiramisu have their charms, having journeyed through his repertoire, I find that the sobacha and strawberry variations better capture the true spirit of Ramirez's soufflé.





Following the frozen soufflé, a celebration cake arrives at the table as we anticipate the arrival of the mignardises. Intended to mark the occasion, the cake proves unexpectedly dense. Its almost rock-like texture makes it difficult to cut through with any degree of elegance. Though its sweetness is commendably restrained for a chocolate cake, the excessive compactness renders it more perplexing than celebratory. In this context, one cannot help but feel that, at this level of execution, the omission of the cake might have been the more considered choice. The presence of this cake inevitably calls to mind the mousse cake once served between the soufflé and the mignardises at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare. In contrast, that iteration displayed a level of finesse and delicacy more in keeping with the expectations of a true French patisserie.

The arrival of the mignardises finally brings a whisper of solace, while gently drawing the curtain on this dégustation journey. First to grace the table are a blackberry tart crowned with a delicate hemisphere of lime jelly, and a buttery biscuit sandwiched with soy caramel. Neither claims to be a cutting-edge creation or overly complex; rather, they offer the simple, soul-soothing comfort one craves at the close of a French feast. Just as we finish the duo, the final act arrives — a chocolate lava cake pulled fresh from the heart of the oven. Much like its predecessors, it is honest and unpretentious. There is a restraint in its sweetness, making for an ending that, while perhaps not breathtaking, is nonetheless profoundly serene and satisfying.



The hours at César pass swiftly, and the entire experience leaves me momentarily surprised that it has already come to an end. A subtle sense of haste lingers throughout the meal — one almost feels as though chasing a departing train — though this may in part be attributed to the abbreviated menu compare to Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare. As we prepare for our departure, the maître d' presents us with a single printed copy of the evening's menu, which strikes me as somewhat unexpected, as most restaurants would provide one for each guest. Upon raising this, he returns to the dining room, remarking only that he will bring back a surprise. By this point, drawing on past experience, it needs no effort for me to anticipate what this surprise entails. Indeed, Ramirez soon emerges to greet us, handing over the menu upon which he has inscribed a simple line: recipes are made to be broken.



César Ramirez's cuisine is not new to me. Previous to my experience at César, I have dined several times at Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, where he was once at the helm, and it remains the only three-Michelin-starred restaurant to which I have returned twice, a fact that speaks plainly enough about my regard for his cooking. Then came something of an earthquake in the gastronomy world. Ramirez and Brooklyn Fare's owner, Moe Issa, fell into a bitter legal dispute. Ramirez accused Issa of unpaid wages and financial misconduct; Issa, in turn, claimed Ramirez had taken valuable wine and expensive tableware to sabotage the business. They split, and Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare lost all of its stars. For those of us who admired Ramirez's intricate yet oddly intimate compositions, the aftermath has been hard to process. His deep understanding of Japanese cuisine married with French techniques inspired a kind of loyalty that's rare and personal. At the same time, the circumstances of his departure make it difficult not to question the man behind it. Ramirez has since opened this restaurant under his own name and quickly earned two Michelin stars. Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, now with new chefs, has also earned two stars back. Today's journey once again affirms Ramirez's finesse and precision, yet it is undermined with a quiet sense of decadence — something unresolved in that symmetry, two parallel restorations, neither quite compensating what was lost.